and might not have been sent to Cambridge for further studies and for competing for the ICS.[8]

Elphinstone College beckoned after matriculation; and Deshmukh continued to shine academically topping both the Previous and Intermediate examinations. He won prizes in Sanskrit and English in the Previous, and in Sanskrit and History in the Intermediate examination, apart from winning a college prize for standing first in Mathematics. For his junior BA, Deshmukh opted for Mathematics, but it was in the first quarter of 1915 that Lagu, his mentor, shaped his future career. Lagu thought that Deshmukh was good enough to appear for the ICS examination. While the idea was well received by Deshmukh's father, financial resources proved to be an impediment. His father had ₹5,000 to spare and agreed to raise a further ₹5,000 through loans.

The sticking point was the additional ₹10,000, needed to finance his trip to England. After a few failed attempts, and largely due to Lagu's persistence, the money was finally raised by a loan from the Hindu Education Society. Prof. Muller, his history teacher, wrote to Jesus College, Cambridge, and his recommendation received a favourable response. Prof. Anderson who taught Indian Administration had written to Trinity College and an assured admission into Trinity also became available. Since they had already communicated acceptance to Jesus, the Trinity offer could not be accepted. For guidance on selection of subjects for the ICS examination, the advice of M.V. Bhide, one of Lagu's contemporaries who had succeeded at the examination was sought. Bhide recommended the Sciences rather than Mathematics as the latter 'was very chancy.'[9] Deshmukh took this advice and made the Sciences the base of his selection for Part I of the Tripos.

Deshmukh sailed for England on May 15, 1915, and landed in London on June 1. At Jesus College, he decided to offer Botany, Chemistry, and Geology for Part I of his Natural Sciences Tripos. His earlier plans of offering Physics as one of the subjects were abandoned somewhat precipitately, when he failed to set up an experiment at the Physics laboratory and was reproached for it by one of the teachers. Botany too, he offered somewhat diffidently after being warned by P.K. Chari, an Indian student, who said that Botany needed drawing skills. Deshmukh confessed to limited ability in this field but finally opted for Botany since Zoology